

Nicholas Swanson
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CURRENT POSITIONS:

Assistant Professor, Cornell University, Department of Economics

AFFILIATIONS:

Weiss Fund nominated researcher (as of 2026)

J-PAL invited researcher (as of 2026)

PAST POSITIONS:

Postdoctoral Fellow, Stanford University, King Center on Global Development – 2024–2025

FIELDS OF CONCENTRATION:

Development Economics, Behavioral Economics, Labor Economics

EDUCATION:

	DEGREE	DATE	FIELD
University of California, Berkeley	PhD	2024	Economics
LSE <i>Distinction</i>	M.Sc.	2015	Economics
University of Cambridge <i>First-Class Honors</i>	B.A.	2011	Economics

WORKING PAPERS:

1. **“All in the Family: Kinship Pressure and Firm Worker Matching”**
2. **“Under-training by Employers in Informal Labor Markets: Evidence from Burundi”**
with Luisa Cefala, Pedro Naso and Michel Ndayikeza
3. **“The Economic Consequences of Knowledge Hoarding”**
with Luisa Cefala, Franck Irakoze and Pedro Naso
4. **“Retrieval Failures and Consumption Smoothing: A Field Experiment on Seasonal Poverty”**
with Ned Augenblick, Kelsey Jack, Supreet Kaur and Felix Masiye
Conditionally Accepted, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*
5. **“Slum Measurement using Manual and AI Methods”**
with Michael Gechter, Yuting Li, Nancy Lozano Gracia, Minas Sifakis and Nick Tsivanidis
In preparation for the *Journal of Economic Perspectives*

SELECTED WORKS IN PROGRESS:

1. **“Commitment Savings in Farming Populations”**
with Supreet Kaur, Rajdev Kaur and Gautam Rao
2. **“Freeriding and New Product Adoption”**
with Luisa Cefala, Grady Kileen and Redempteur Ntawiratsa
3. **“The Welfare Effects of Easier Liquidity Access for Low-Income Workers: Evidence from Earned Wage Access”**
with Luisa Cefala, Eric Koepcke and Afras Sial

PUBLICATIONS:

1. **“When Outsiders Become Insiders: Beliefs and the Persistence of Exclusionary Norms”**
with Luisa Cefala, Franck Irakoze and Pedro Naso
AEA Papers and Proceedings, 2026
2. **“Research Transparency is on the Rise in Economics”**
with Garret Christensen, Rebecca Littman, David Birke, Edward Miguel, Elizabeth Levy Paluck and Zenan Wang
AEA Papers and Proceedings, 2020 (Vol. 110, pp. 61–65)
3. **“Survey of Open Science Practices and Attitudes in the Social Sciences”**
with Joel Ferguson, Rebecca Littman, Garret Christensen, Elizabeth Levy Paluck, Zenan Wang, Edward Miguel, David Birke and John-Henry Pezzuto
Nature Communications, 2023 (Vol. 14(1), p. 5401)

TEACHING:

ECON 4560: Development Economics (Spring 2026)

ECON 4960: Field Experiments in Economics (Spring 2026)

Teaching Assistant, MBA Programs, Haas School of Business (Spring 2020)

Strategic Leadership

Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (Fall 2018, Spring 2019)

Introduction to Economics, Intermediate Microeconomics

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

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| 2026 | ASSA, Midwest International Development Conference, Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting |
| 2025 | ASSA, University of Washington, PacDev, CSAE, Cornell, Princeton NLSE, UC Davis, Networks and Development (own and co-author presentation), BREAD (own and co-author presentation), Firms, Labor Markets, and Development, NBER SI Development (co-author presentation), Stanford SITE Missing Markets |
| 2024 | CSAE Conference, Networks and Development, BREAD, NBER SI Development, USC, Harvard-MIT, Yale Y-Rise |
| 2023 | PacDev, Warwick PhD Conference, All UC Labor, Advances in Field Experiments, IZA/CREST Conference: Labor Market Policy Evaluation, World Bank Dime-KDI, NEUDC |
| 2022 | Advances in Field Experiments, STEG Workshop, IPA GPRL, NEUDC |
| 2021 | PEP Convening, PacDev, Early-Career Behavioral Economics Conference |
| 2020 | Yale Whitebox Conference |

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS:

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|------------|-----------------------------------|
| 2024 | CEGA Doctoral Dissertation Award |
| 2023 | Stone Center Fellowship |
| 2023 | IRLE Dissertation Fellowship |
| 2022 | Global Priorities Fellowship |
| 2021/2022 | Rocca Dissertation Fellowship |
| 2009, 2011 | Kings Scholar, Gerald Shove Prize |

RESEARCH GRANTS:

PI

2025	CCSS (\$10,000), PEDL Scale up Grant (~\$35,000)
2024	IGC (~\$26,000), PEDL (~\$40,000), GDRF (~\$27,000), CEGA (\$15,000)
2023	IGC (~\$25,000), Strandberg Research Grant (\$9,300)
2022	SurveyCTO Research Grant Awardee (\$2,000), Weiss Fund (\$48,120), Weiss Fund (\$44,660)
2022	Strandberg Research Grant (\$10,000)
2021–23	Psychology and Economics of Poverty Grants (multiple) (\$39,000)
2021	ATAI (\$8,527), JPal-JOI (\$7,310)
2020	PEDL Exploratory Grant (~\$40,000), EASST Grant Award (\$54,250)
2018–23	CEGA Development Challenge (multiple) (\$23,500)

Co-PI

2024	WAM (\$1,500,000), JPAL SPI (\$250,000), USAID-DIV (\$1,500,000)
2022	IGC (~\$25,000)
2020	USAID-DIV (\$426,146)
2020	MRR (\$256,716)
2019	Weiss Foundation (\$75,862)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE:

Research Assistant (with Nick Tsivanidis), Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (2021–2022)
Research Assistant (with Supreet Kaur), Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (2017–2018)
Research Assistant (with Ted Miguel), Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (2017–2018)
Research Assistant (with Nava Ashraf), Department of Economics, LSE (2015–2016)
Research Assistant (with Heather Schofield, Frank Schilbach), Cornell and MIT (2013–2014)

OTHER EXPERIENCE:

M&A Analyst, Evercore Partners, 2013–2014
Equity Research Analyst, HSBC, 2011–2012

SERVICE

Committees: Cornell Placement Committee (2025)

Discussions: Varun Kapoor, UCSD Indian Economy Center discussion series (2026); Dev Patel, ASSA 2026; Mayara Felix, ASSA 2026

Referee: American Economic Journal: Applied Economics; American Economic Review; Journal of Development Economics; Journal of the European Economic Association; Journal of Political Economy; Review of Economics and Statistics

OTHER INFORMATION:

Citizenship: UK, USA